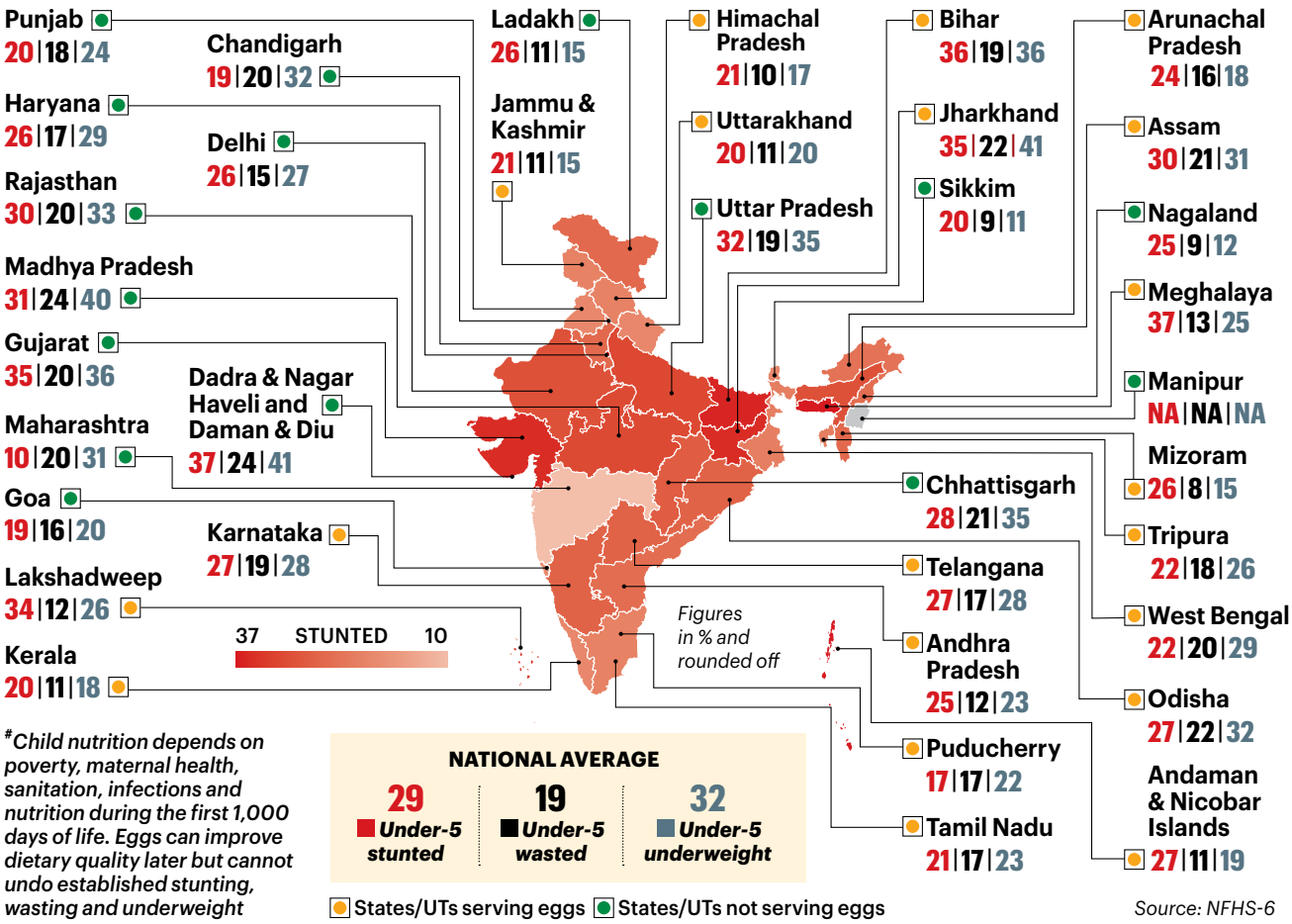


#Child nutrition depends on poverty, maternal health, sanitation, infections and nutrition during the first 1,000 days of life. Eggs can improve dietary quality later but cannot undo established stunting, wasting and underweight

ADDRESSING CONCERNS

The real issue arises when centralised vegetarian suppliers become central to the debate. ISKCON and its related charitable arms do not cook meat, fish or eggs because their food is first offered as *prasadam* in the Gaudiya Vaishnava tradition. Akshaya Patra, established by ISKCON devotees, retains a 'lacto-vegetarian' regimen that excludes eggs. It says its meals meet government PM POSHAN norms through cereals, pulses, soy, paneer and local vegetarian recipes. It designs menus for each state: rice, *sambhar* and *bisi bele bath* in Karnataka; *dalma* in Odisha; *sukhadi* in Gujarat; dal, chawal, khichdi and vegetable curries in northern states. It argues that whether children get eggs depends on the contract governments choose, not on the service provider.

The poultry industry, too, sees the debate as larger than its commercial interests. As more Indians become aware of nutrient deficiencies, particularly of protein, egg consumption has been rising steadily. Average annual per capita egg consumption has increased from 84 eggs before the COVID-19 pandemic to 104 today. Midday meals are a significant part of this ecosystem. Around 30 million eggs are served through school meals every day across the country, nearly 8 per cent of India's total egg production. "Not even 50 per cent of the policy on providing eggs through midday meals is being implemented," says Uday Singh Bayas, president of Poultry India/IPEMA, pointing to the number of states that either do not offer eggs at all or serve them only once or twice a week.

For the poultry industry, however, state-level bans or withdrawals have only a limited and temporary effect. The bigger annual challenges for the sector, Bayas says, are bird mortality, disease outbreaks and fluctuating feed costs. "Banning eggs in midday meals is not a major issue for the industry. However, from a nutrition perspective, after mother's milk, eggs are among the purest forms of food, and should be encouraged," he says. One argument egg opponents often raise is the alleged use of antibiotics in poultry, something that, Bayas says, is being used to keep eggs out of school meals. He says the industry uses only government-approved antibiotics and follows prescribed permissible limits. Most poultry farmers, he adds, are small-scale producers who do not have the financial capacity to use antibiotics excessively. These medicines are expensive and are used only when necessary.

He also points to the recent controversy involving Eggoz, where allegations were made about prohibited antibiotic residues in eggs. The Food Safety and Standards Authority of India (FSSAI) later clarified that eggs available in the country are safe for human consumption and that claims linking eggs to cancer risk are misleading and scientifically unsupported. For the industry, the conclusion is simple: if quality control is the concern, regulate better; do not remove one of the most affordable protein foods from the plates of poor children.